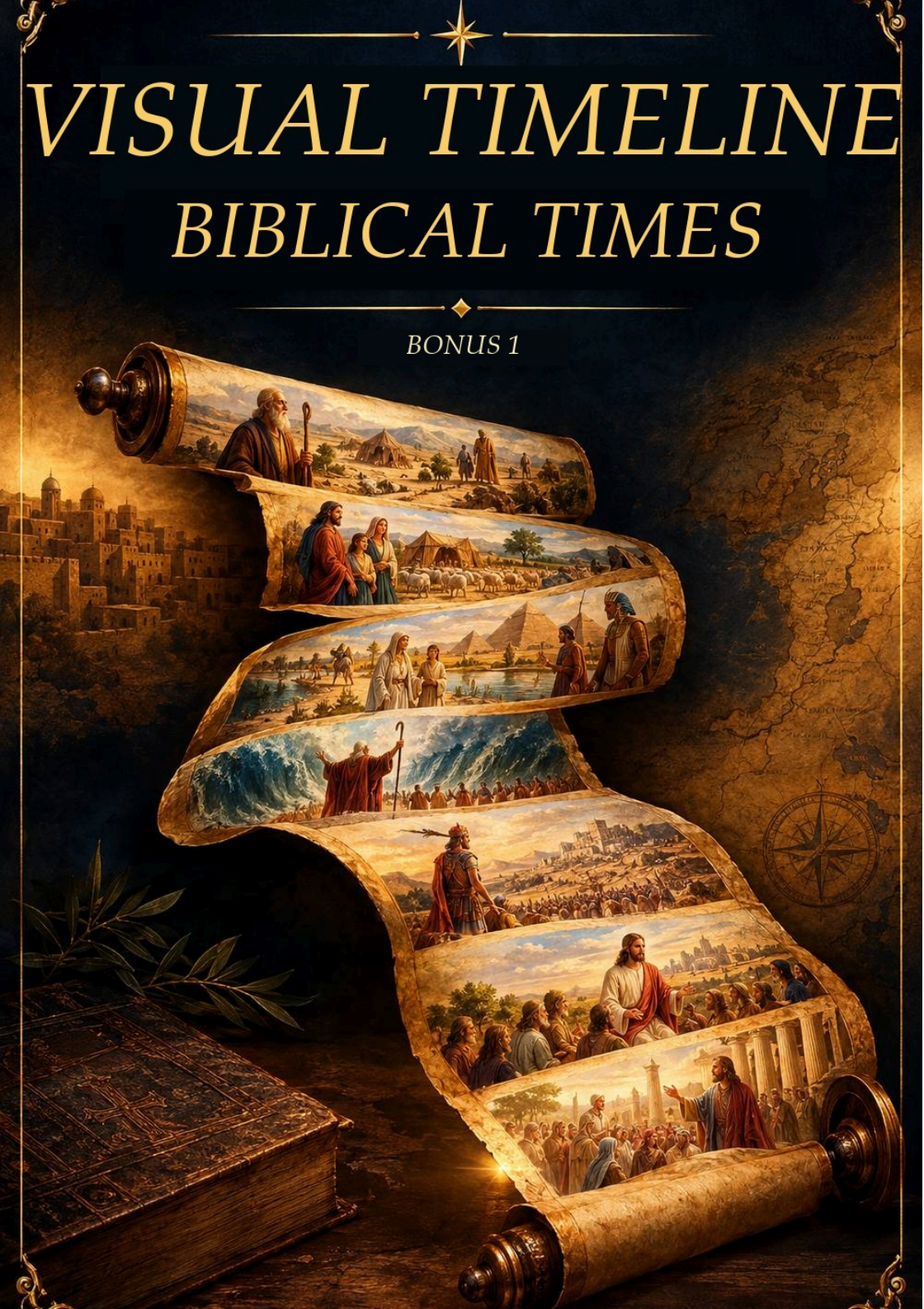
VISUAL TIMELINE

BIBLICAL TIMES

BONUS 1



BONUS 1

Visual Bible Timeline™

From the patriarchs to the Early Church in twelve eras, on one clear timeline.

Biblical history stretches across more than two thousand years and is hard to grasp without a clear order. This timeline divides it into twelve eras, from Abraham's wanderings to the first Christian communities. For each era you will find a short description, the key facts, a box with an interesting detail, and references to Scripture. This makes it easier to see who lived before whom and which events took place at the same time.

Remember that dates in antiquity are approximate. That is why most of them are marked “c.,” and in disputed matters we give two hypotheses. The timeline does not settle scholarly debates, but helps you read the Bible in the context of Near Eastern history. You can browse it in order or return to a chosen era whenever a new name, city, or empire appears in your reading.

01

The Patriarchs

C. 2000–1700 BC · MESOPOTAMIA AND CANAAN



The Bible's timeline begins with people who lived in tents, not palaces. Abraham set out from Ur in Mesopotamia, through Haran, to the land of Canaan, and according to tradition this was the beginning of the great story of the covenant. After him came Isaac and Jacob, shepherds of flocks of sheep and goats, who moved between Shechem, Bethel, Hebron, and Beersheba. Their world did not yet know an Israelite state, but it knew wells, pastures, and clan agreements on which the survival of the whole family depended for generations. For this reason the patriarchs are remembered as figures close to ordinary people, who trust a promise despite the lack of visible proof.

Dates from this period are approximate, because the Bible does not give a calendar in our sense. Scholars place the age of the patriarchs roughly at the beginning of the second millennium BC, when city-states ruled in Mesopotamia and the Middle Kingdom ruled in Egypt. Imagine a caravan of donkeys traveling for many weeks along the Fertile

Crescent. Such a journey from Haran to Canaan is c. 800–900 km, and every stop required access to water and good relations with the local people. This rhythm of marching, stops at wells, and negotiating for pasture captures well the daily life of that age, far removed from the later great cities and temples.

- Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob: three generations of the covenant
- Main centers: Shechem, Bethel, Hebron, Beersheba
- Way of life: semi-nomadic herding
- Route from Ur to Canaan: c. 1,500 km

WHY ARE THE DATES CAUTIOUS?

Ancient biblical texts count time by generations and events, not by calendar year. That is why every date for the patriarchs is a hypothesis based on comparisons with Near Eastern history. A broader principle remains constant: the order of events is clear, and we always give absolute years with “c.” so as not to suggest a certainty the sources do not provide.

02

Egypt

C. 1700–1300 BC · NILE DELTA

The story of Joseph carries the reader from the pastures of Canaan to the Nile. Sold by his brothers, he ended up in Egypt, where through wisdom he gained high office and saved the country from famine. His family settled in the fertile land of Goshen, in the eastern part of the delta, which offered pasture for flocks. Over the following generations Jacob's descendants grew in number, and Egypt became for them both a refuge and a place of increasingly hard life. This family thread is important, because from one family a whole nation later grows, and Joseph's story shows forgiveness that rises above old wrongs.

The Bible speaks of four centuries or four generations of sojourn, and scholars debate the exact chronology. We know that Egypt welcomed newcomers from Asia, as confirmed by tomb paintings showing Semitic caravans. In time the rule changed, and a new ruler who did not know Joseph's service began to treat the Israelites as cheap labor for building store cities. The Nile delta is c. 240 km wide at the coast, flat and rich in water. Thus the Egyptian era joins two worlds: the pastures of Canaan and the monumental culture of the pharaohs, which speaks through pyramids, temples, and numerous administrative records.

- Joseph: from slavery to governor
- Goshen: the eastern Nile delta
- Israelites labor on city building projects
- Sojourn lasts c. 400 years by tradition

WHAT DOES GOSHEN MEAN?

Goshen is the name of the land where Jacob's family settled, and its exact location is placed in the area of Wadi Tumilat in the eastern delta. It was land good for grazing and close to the road to Canaan. This location is traditional and probable, but no inscription naming the Israelites confirms it.

03

The Exodus

C. 1446 OR C. 1260 BC · EGYPT – SINAI



The Exodus from Egypt is the central event of the Old Testament. Under Moses' leadership the people left the land of bondage, passed through the waters, and set out across the desert toward Mount Sinai, where according to tradition they received the Law. The story joins the drama of freedom with daily concern for bread and water: manna, quail, and springs appear in it as gifts along the way. The Exodus later became the pattern for all stories of rescue and for the feast of Passover. We find traces of this journey later in feasts, prayers, and songs, in which generations return in thought to the day of liberation.

Chronologists divide into two main schools: the earlier dates the Exodus to c. 1446 BC, the later to c. 1260 BC, during the reign of Ramesses II. Both try to reconcile the text with archaeological discoveries. The location of Mount Sinai also varies: tradition points to Jebel Musa in the south of the peninsula, which rises to c. 2,285 m above sea level. Imagine narrow valleys, cold nights, and hot days, through which walked families with children and

flocks. In this story the desert plays the role of a school: it teaches trust, community, and responsibility, and the place where the Law was received becomes a reference point for all later faith.

- Moses leads the people through the Sea of Reeds
- Sinai: the gift of the Law and the covenant
- Two main datings: c. 1446 and c. 1260 BC
- Wandering in the desert: 40 years by tradition

THE DEBATE OVER THE DATE

Scholars divide into supporters of an early and a late date for the Exodus. The first rely on the mention of 480 years in the Book of Kings, the second on traces of Ramesses' building works and changes in Canaan. The reader need not settle the dispute to grasp the message: the event matters as the foundation of the nation's identity and faith.

04

The Judges

C. 1200–1050 BC · CANAAN

After entering the Promised Land under Joshua, the tribes settled in the hills and valleys of Canaan, but did not yet form one state. The time of the judges is a period in which local leaders, such as Deborah, Gideon, or Samson, rallied the people in moments of danger. The pattern of the Book of Judges repeats: faithfulness, decline, oppression, cry for help, and deliverance. The unity of the tribes could be fragile, and disputes among them happened as often as joint campaigns. The Book of Ruth, set in the same time, shows the other side of the era: quiet village life, harvests, family loyalty, and care for a foreigner.

Archaeologists describe this time as an age of transition from the Late Bronze to the Iron Age, when many small settlements appeared in the hills of Ephraim and Judah. New technologies, such as water cisterns and terraced fields, made it possible to live on hills where no one had lived before. Agriculture relied on grain, olives, and grapevines. The period ends when the Philistines, strong with iron technology, began to threaten the tribes and a call for a king arose. The story of this period reminds us, then, that the nation did not arise in a moment, but matured over centuries of change, crises, and returns to common roots.

- Deborah, Gideon, Jephthah, and Samson as judges
- Threats: Canaanites, Midianites, Philistines
- Hill settlements with terraces and cisterns
- The period is closed by the prophet Samuel

WHO WAS A JUDGE?

The Hebrew word means not only a person who settles disputes, but also a leader who delivers the people. The judges did not form a permanent office or a dynasty. Their power came from authority and trust, so it could be short and limited to one region or a few tribes.

05

The United Kingdom

C. 1030–930 BC · ISRAEL AND JUDAH



Under pressure from the Philistines, the tribes demanded a king. The first was Saul, after him power passed to David, who captured Jerusalem and made it his capital, and then to his son Solomon. According to the Bible, this is the period of greatest unity and flourishing: borders were strengthened, trade developed, and the first temple was built on Mount Moriah. David is also remembered as the author of many psalms, and Solomon as a symbol of wisdom and wealth, to whom guests came from distant lands. For the reader it is important that the kings' successes are described alongside their mistakes, which makes the Bible not a eulogy of power, but an honest witness to human weakness.

Each of these three reigns lasted, according to tradition, c. 40 years, which gives round numbers and underlines their symbolic meaning. Jerusalem lies at an elevation of c. 750 m above sea level, on a mountain ridge, away from the main trade routes, but close to the north–south road. Solomon developed trade with Phoenicia and Arabia, built fortified cities such as Hazor, Megiddo, and Gezer, and the temple was the center of worship for the whole people. The exact

extent of the kingdom of David and Solomon is debated by archaeologists, but all agree that Jerusalem then became the center of politics and worship.

- Saul, David, Solomon: three kings
- Jerusalem becomes the capital
- The temple on Mount Moriah
- Trade with Phoenicia and Arabia

WHY JERUSALEM?

David chose a city that belonged to none of the tribes, so it favored neither north nor south. It lay on the border of Judah and Benjamin and had a defensible hill with a reliable water source, the Gihon. It was both a political and a symbolic choice, which shaped history for the following millennia.

06

The Divided Kingdom

C. 930–722 BC · ISRAEL AND JUDAH

After Solomon's death the state split into two parts. In the north arose the Kingdom of Israel with its capital in Samaria, in the south the Kingdom of Judah with Jerusalem. The causes were taxes, heavy forced labor, and rivalry among the tribes. Israel was larger and richer, but politically unstable; over two centuries several dynasties changed there. Judah held to the dynasty of David and the temple, so it was smaller in scale but had greater continuity. These divisions show how quickly unity falls apart when justice toward the weaker is lacking, as the prophets repeatedly reminded the people.

This is the time of the prophets: Elijah and Elisha worked in the north, while Amos and Hosea rebuked the people over injustice. Both states lay between great powers, Egypt in the south and Assyria in the northeast, so their fate depended on alliances. The distance from Samaria to Jerusalem is only c. 60 km, yet the two kingdoms often waged war and only rarely cooperated. The period ends with the fall of Samaria in c. 722 BC. The influence of neighbors, including Aram with Damascus and Phoenicia with Tyre, was visible in trade, art, and religious disputes, which often took on political significance.

- Israel (north) and Judah (south)
- Capitals: Samaria and Jerusalem
- Prophets: Elijah, Elisha, Amos, Hosea
- End of the north: c. 722 BC

TWO KINGDOMS, ONE BIBLE

Although the states were separated, the texts of the shared tradition preserved the memory of both. The Books of Kings and Chronicles describe the history of both dynasties, but each from a different point of view. Reading them together helps us notice that history is not a simple chronicle, but a story with a religious message.

07

Assyria

C. 745–609 BC · NEAR EAST

In the eighth century BC Assyria grew into the greatest power of the region. Its kings, such as Tiglath-Pileser III, Shalmaneser V, and Sargon II, waged wars, resettled populations, and imposed tribute. In c. 722 BC Samaria fell, and a large part of the northern population was deported. For Judah it was a cautionary lesson; King Hezekiah strengthened Jerusalem and built a tunnel to secure water for the city during a siege. From Judah's perspective it was a time of fear, but also of spiritual awakening, because many prophecies about trust and peace were written down then.

In 701 BC Sennacherib besieged Jerusalem after capturing many cities of Judah. The Bible tells that the city was saved, which it links with Hezekiah's prayer and the word of the prophet Isaiah. Assyrian inscriptions speak of a siege and tribute, so the sources show the same event from another side. The Assyrian capital, Nineveh, lay on the Tigris, c. 800 km northeast of Jerusalem. In 612 BC it was captured by the Babylonians and Medes. Museums around the world today hold Assyrian reliefs of the siege of Lachish, which show soldiers, siege engines, and fleeing inhabitants.

- Fall of Samaria: c. 722 BC
- Siege of Jerusalem: 701 BC
- Prophets: Isaiah, Micah, Nahum, Jonah
- Nineveh captured in 612 BC

HEZEKIAH'S TUNNEL

Beneath Jerusalem runs a channel cut into the rock, which carried water from the Gihon spring to a reservoir inside the walls. It is c. 530 m long and recalls the preparations for the siege. It is one of the best-known traces of the era, preserved and open to visitors to this day.

08

Babylon

C. 605–539 BC · MESOPOTAMIA



When Babylon defeated Assyria and Egypt, it became the new master of the region. Nebuchadnezzar II besieged Jerusalem three times; in 587/586 BC the city was captured and the temple burned. Many inhabitants of Judah were carried off to Babylonia. This experience of exile became one of the deepest turning points in the nation's history: it lost its land, its king, and its temple, but kept the Word and its memory. The Book of Lamentations, written after the fall of the city, is among the most moving texts about grief and hope, and is still read during Holy Week today.

The exiles settled along the canals of the Euphrates, including by the River Chebar. The prophets Ezekiel and Daniel spoke to the community there, while Jeremiah wrote a letter from Jerusalem telling them to build houses and seek the peace of the city. Babylon was one of the greatest cities of antiquity; its walls and the Ishtar Gate still amaze today in museum reconstruction. The road from Jerusalem to Babylon is c. 1,400 km along the Fertile Crescent, and covering it took

months. As hope faded, faith also appeared in a new covenant, which Jeremiah described as written on hearts, and not only on tablets.

- Capture of Jerusalem: 587/586 BC
- Exile by the Euphrates
- Prophets: Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Daniel
- The exiles' journey: c. 1,400 km

EXILE AS A NEW BEGINNING

In a foreign land without a temple, collections of writings, common prayer, and study developed. Many traditions were organized precisely then, which laid the foundation for the later synagogue. For this reason exile is described as a time of loss and, at the same time, of deep renewal of identity.

09

Persia

C. 539–332 BC · PERSIAN NEAR EAST

In 539 BC Cyrus the Great captured Babylon and allowed peoples to return to their homelands. The first exiles returned to Jerusalem under Zerubbabel and Joshua, and later Ezra and Nehemiah continued rebuilding the temple and the walls. The rebuilding was modest and difficult; the people were few and the surroundings hostile. Even so, the second temple was built, dedicated in c. 515 BC. The return did not mean full restoration of former glory, but the beginning of a new stage in which the community gathered around the Law and prayer.

Persia was a vast empire, from India to Egypt, governed by satraps and held together by a network of roads, such as the Royal Road. Judea was a small province, Yehud. Its inhabitants lived under Persian royal law, and the local community, led by priests, sustained its traditions. In this time the books of Ezra, Nehemiah, and Esther were written or edited, and the writing of the prophetic books, such as Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi, was also coming to an end. Persia remained a gracious ruler for most of the period, and the Book of Esther tells how the Jews were saved in one of the cities of the empire.

- Edict of Cyrus: c. 538 BC
- Second temple: c. 515 BC
- Nehemiah rebuilds the walls: c. 445 BC
- Books: Ezra, Neh, Esth, Hag, Zech, Mal

CYRUS IN THE SOURCES

A well-known inscription called the Cyrus Cylinder shows that the king pursued a policy of respect toward the gods and temples of conquered peoples. This is consistent with the general picture from the Book of Ezra, although the text of the cylinder does not mention the Jews directly. For historians it is an important example of how outside sources complement the Bible.

10

The Intertestamental Period

C. 332–6 BC · GREECE, EGYPT, SYRIA, ROME

After the conquests of Alexander the Great in 332 BC, Judea entered the Hellenistic world. After the commander's death his realm fell apart; Judea was ruled first by the Ptolemies of Egypt, then by the Seleucids of Syria. In Alexandria the Greek translation of Scripture, the Septuagint, was made. The Greek language, Greek-style cities, and new ideas influenced daily life; some Jews adopted the new customs, while others strongly opposed them. It was in this era that the world Jesus found took shape, with synagogues, scribes, and tension between faithfulness to tradition and openness to Greek civilization.

Under Antiochus IV Epiphanes came persecution and the desecration of the temple, which sparked the Maccabean revolt in c. 167 BC. After the war the Hasmonean dynasty ruled, until in 63 BC Pompey entered Jerusalem and Judea came under Roman rule. Herod the Great, king by Roman favor from 37 BC, rebuilt the temple on a grand scale. This is the time when the groups of the Pharisees, Sadducees, and Essenes took shape. For the historian it is a period rich in sources, and for the reader of the Bible a bridge connecting the last books of the Old Testament with the beginning of the Gospels.

- Alexander the Great: 332 BC
- Septuagint: Greek translation in Alexandria
- Maccabean revolt: c. 167 BC
- Pompey in Jerusalem: 63 BC

BOOKS FROM THIS TIME

In the Catholic tradition, the books that arose or were completed in this period belong to Scripture, including 1 and 2 Maccabees, Wisdom, and Sirach. They help us understand the climate of the era and the tensions that preceded the time of Jesus. Not all Christian communities treat them the same way, so it is worth noting this difference calmly.

11

The Time of Jesus

C. 6 BC – 30 AD · GALILEE, JUDEA, JERUSALEM



Jesus was born in Bethlehem during the reign of Herod the Great, and grew up in Nazareth in Galilee. Around the age of thirty he began his public ministry: he taught by the Sea of Galilee, in Capernaum, and in the surrounding villages, called disciples, and healed the sick. He spent his last days in Jerusalem, where he was condemned to death by crucifixion under Pontius Pilate. According to the witness of the Gospels, he rose on the third day. Around the Sea of Galilee lay bustling fishing settlements, and trade routes such as the Via Maris connected the region with Damascus and the coast.

The exact dates are debated. The year of birth is usually placed between 6 and 4 BC, because Herod died in c. 4 BC, and the crucifixion in 30 or 33 AD. Palestine was then divided into Galilee, Judea, Samaria, and other regions, ruled by Herod's sons or Roman prefects. The journey from Nazareth to Jerusalem is c. 130 km on foot and took

several days, usually through the Jordan Valley. Roman administration, taxes on the population, and the presence of the army affected daily life, and messianic hopes were alive in many circles in that age.

- Bethlehem, Nazareth, Capernaum, Jerusalem
- Public ministry: c. 3 years
- Crucifixion: c. 30 or 33 AD
- Authorities: Herod Antipas and Pontius Pilate

HISTORICAL SOURCES

Besides the four Gospels, Roman and Jewish authors also mention Jesus, including Josephus and Tacitus. These are brief mentions, but they confirm that Jesus lived and was executed under Pilate. The witness of faith contained in the Gospels, however, goes beyond mere history and is read in the tradition of the Church.

12

The Early Church

C. 30–100 AD · JERUSALEM – ROME



After the coming of the Holy Spirit in Jerusalem, the disciples began to proclaim the Gospel. At first the community consisted of Jews, but soon the Good News reached Samaria, Antioch, and beyond. In Antioch the disciples were first called Christians. The apostles, among them Peter, James, and John, led the Church in Jerusalem. The communities were united by prayer, the breaking of bread, the teaching of the apostles, and care for the poor. The spread of the faith was helped by the Jewish diaspora, synagogues in port cities, and the network of roads and sea routes that connected the empire.

A special role was played by Paul of Tarsus, who made three missionary journeys through Asia Minor, Greece, and Macedonia, and finally arrived in Rome. He wrote letters to communities such as Rome, Corinth, Galatia, and Philippi. Roman roads and the common Greek language made travel easier; Paul covered in total many thousands of kilometers. At the end of the first century the last writings of the New Testament were composed, and the Church was already present throughout the whole basin

of the Mediterranean Sea. From the perspective of history, this was therefore the era in which a small community from Jerusalem became, within a few decades, a movement present in the most important cities of the ancient world.

- Coming of the Holy Spirit: c. 30 AD
- Council of Jerusalem: c. 49 AD
- Paul's three missionary journeys
- Letters and books: end of the first century

WHY ANTIOCH?

Antioch on the Orontes was one of the largest cities of the empire, with a mixed Jewish and pagan population. From here the missions of Paul and Barnabas set out. Its role shows how the Church moved from a local Jewish community into the great Roman and Greek world.

SUMMARY

Overview Table

ERA	DATE (APPROX.)	KEY FIGURES AND EVENTS
The Patriarchs	c. 2000–1700 BC	Abraham, Isaac, Jacob
Egypt	c. 1700–1300 BC	Joseph, sojourn in Goshen
The Exodus	c. 1446 or 1260 BC	Moses, Sinai
The Judges	c. 1200–1050 BC	Deborah, Gideon, Samson
The United Kingdom	c. 1030–930 BC	Saul, David, Solomon
The Divided Kingdom	c. 930–722 BC	Israel and Judah, prophets
Assyria	c. 745–609 BC	Fall of Samaria, Hezekiah
Babylon	c. 605–539 BC	Destruction of the temple, exile
Persia	c. 539–332 BC	Return, second temple
The Intertestamental Period	c. 332–6 BC	Septuagint, Maccabees
The Time of Jesus	c. 6 BC–30 AD	Jesus, Galilee, Jerusalem
The Early Church	c. 30–100 AD	Apostles, Paul

The twelve eras form one story, which runs from a family of shepherds to communities scattered across the whole Mediterranean world. The next time you open the Bible, check on the timeline which era you are in. You will see how events fit together and how to better understand the words

of the prophets, the psalms, or the letters of the apostles. We encourage you to treat this timeline as a permanent reference point in study, family reading, or group meetings.